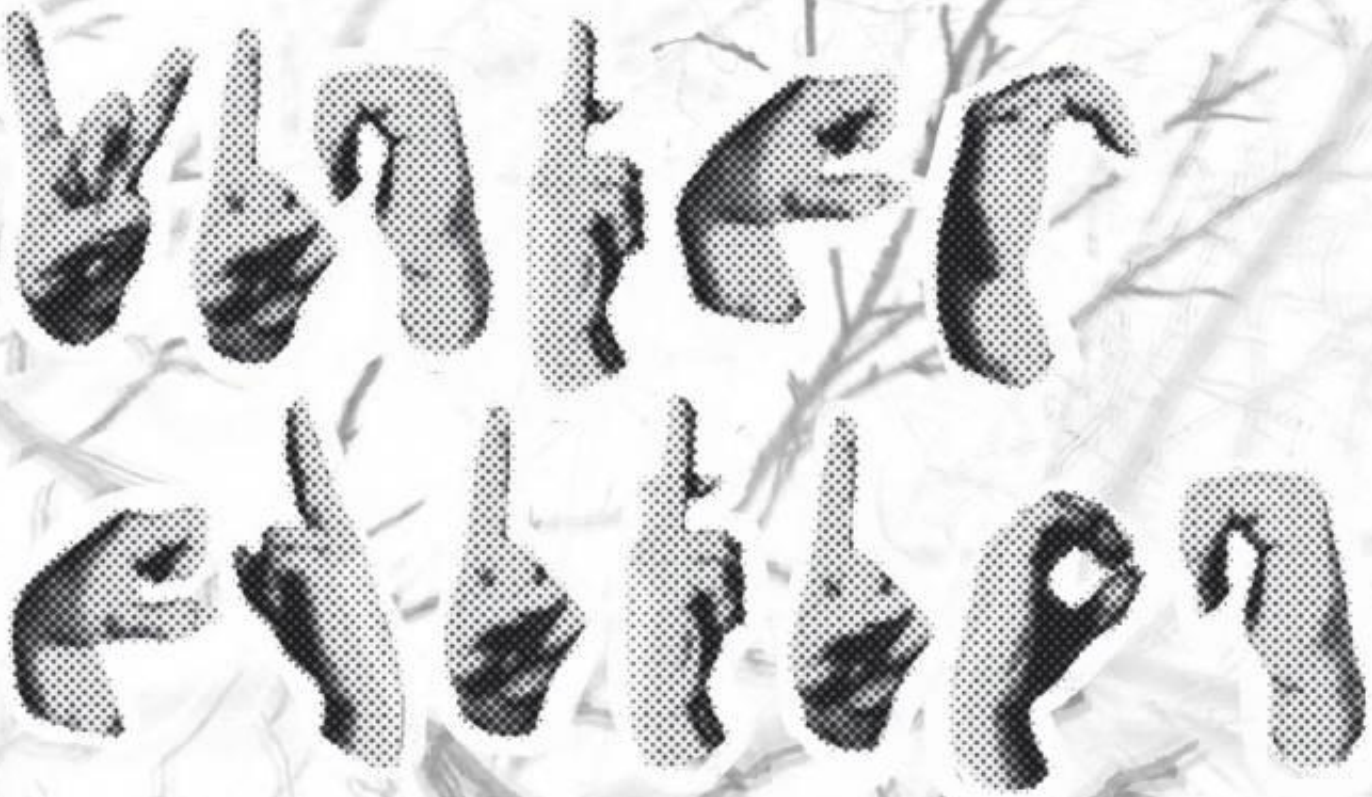
ADM



ART AND DESIGN MAGAZINE EDITION O2

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LETTER FROM THE EDITOR

Hi! My name is Cara, and I'm the Editor-in-Chief of ADM. We're excited to present the first issue of the 2025–2026 school year.

The Visual Academy supports numerous school publications, yet we didn't have one of our own. Our goal was to create something fun and visually engaging for our community. We realized we already had all the right tools - and the talented students - to make something like this possible. Despite the challenges along the way, the experience was absolutely worth it to see the final result.

This winter issue features a variety of exciting articles, including our Design Spotlight that appears in every issue. Our Industry Insider features Rafael Esquer, founder of Alfalfa Studio, a branding and graphic design agency based in New York. This issue's Artist Profile focuses on Monica Shulman.

You'll also find a feature on two Chelsea gallery exhibitions, as well as two articles (including a behind-the-scenes look) on the Visual Academy's Haunted Mansion, which took place just before Halloween in October 2025.

This issue is only possible due to the hard work and dedication of our writers and designers. We would also like to thank Mr. Esquer and Ms. Shulman for generously contributing to the magazine.

On behalf of the entire ADM team, we hope you enjoy the issue!

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INDUSTRY INSIDER



RAFAEL ESQUER

Alfalfa Studio is a branding and graphic design firm led by Rafael Esquer and located in Sugar Hill, the historic West Harlem neighborhood of New York City. Since 2004, the studio has been creating truly inspiring work for brands in sports, arts and culture, and entertainment.

What is your process for creating a brand? Is it consistent across every project?

We follow a clear structure, but every project has its own personality.

First, we listen. A lot. We ask questions about goals, audience, competition, vision. You can't design something meaningful if you don't understand the story behind it.

Then we create a Design Brief. Think of it like a game plan. It keeps everyone aligned before we even sketch.

After that comes exploration: mood boards, research, sketching by hand, testing ideas. We usually develop three strong creative directions and present them with clear reasoning.

Once one direction is chosen, we refine it and build the full system. At the end, we deliver all the files plus brand guidelines, basically a rulebook to keep the brand consistent everywhere.

The steps are consistent. The creative journey is always new.

Why is branding important for small businesses? and how have you seen this firsthand - not only as a brand designer but as a small business owner?

Branding is what makes people remember you.

Small businesses don't have unlimited budgets. A strong brand helps them look credible, professional, and trustworthy from day one. It tells their story without them having to explain it every time.

As a small business owner myself, I see this every day. Your brand isn't just your logo — it's your website, your Instagram, your packaging, even how you respond to emails.

When everything feels cohesive, people feel confident choosing you.

What makes a strong logo? And what if clients disagree?

A strong logo is simple, memorable, and timeless.

If it's overly trendy, it won't age well. If it's too complex, it won't scale.

When clients disagree, I go back to strategy. Good branding isn't about "I like blue" or "I don't like circles."



photo credits Chuy Ortega

It's about what works for the audience and the long-term vision.

I explain the thinking behind every decision. When you can clearly explain why something works, people feel more confident.

And sometimes? You have to gently guide them. That's part of the job.

What was the most challenging project you've taken on?

Designing the official logo for New York City Football Club.

It involved multiple organizations — NYCFC, the Yankees, Manchester City — and a lot of stakeholders. That meant pressure and very high expectations.

The logo had to represent New York authentically while fitting into a global soccer family.
I relied on research, symbolism, and storytelling. Every detail had meaning.
When you design with purpose, you can defend your ideas with confidence.
Seeing it in stadiums today is still surreal.



New York City Football Club © 2024 Alfalfa Studio.

How does being in New York City affect your work?

New York pushes you.
The level of talent, competition, and creativity here is intense. It forces you to grow.
I moved to New York from Sonora, Mexico, with big dreams and very little certainty. Building a studio here wasn't easy. But the city rewards persistence.
It teaches you resilience. And resilience is everything in a creative career.

What skills or software are most useful?

I use Adobe Illustrator, Photoshop, *InDesign, and After Effects regularly.*
But honestly, the most important skills aren't software-based.
It's critical thinking. Communication. Presentation. Curiosity.
Software will evolve. Your ability to think clearly and explain your ideas will always matter.

Any tips for dealing with creative block?

Start anyway.
Creative block usually comes from overthinking. Don't wait for inspiration. Sketch something. Write something. Design something, even if it's bad.
Action creates momentum.
Most blocks live in our minds. The only way through them is movement.

What advice would you give students interested in design?

Be curious about everything. Design isn't just about making things look good. It's about understanding people, culture, history, psychology, and business. The more you observe the world, the better designer you become.
Practice constantly. Build things. Don't wait until you feel "ready." You grow by doing.

And make sure you genuinely love it. This career requires patience, resilience, and long hours of problem-solving.
I came from a small town in Sonora, Mexico, and built a creative career in New York City. It didn't happen overnight. It happened because I stayed consistent, stayed curious, and didn't quit when things got hard.
If you're serious about design, remember this:
Talent opens the door. Discipline keeps it open.





Houston Rockets © 2024 Alfalfa Studio.



Made in NY © 2024 Alfalfa Studio.



To see more from Rafael and his team, visit www.alfalfastudio.com

THE CHELSEA GALLERIES

By Eunice Cho and Gabriela Iwuc

During the autumn season, art galleries experience a surge in sales, often driven by the holidays. The change of seasons also marks the opening of a new batch of exhibitions to the public. Editors Eunice Cho and Gabriela Iwuc took the opportunity to visit a few galleries in the Chelsea area this past November.







MARIKO MORI'S *RADIANCE*

An exhibition that was on display until December 20, 2025, Mariko Mori's Radiance was a show worth visiting. The gallery showcased several of Mori's latest works, which are heavily inspired by Japanese cultural and spiritual traditions. Her work varies from decorative silk and /paper displays featuring clean, radial compositions to luminous, dichroic, stone-shaped sculptures that entirely transform modest environments. Exploring ideas of spiritual transcendence, the interconnections and bindings between living beings, and the concept of the soul– Mariko Mori pieced together a visually and psychologically engaging production.

The centerpiece of the display was an immersive installation reminiscent of the sacred experiences of entering Japanese shrines. A white platform is fenced by sheer, silk veils





that enclosed the space, containing two opposed radiant acrylic glass sculptures. The viewer entered the space with shoe coverings so as to not dirty the pristine area, highlighting both the spiritual and physical cleanliness that lives within the installation's borders. The space offered viewers an opportunity for reflection; a time to curiously wander, observe, and indulge in a space saturated with quiet and tranquil. Mariko Mori's Radiance exhibits other unique works and compositions that reflect her ongoing influences by Japanese spiritual practices and personal interpretations of metaphysical experiences. Altogether, the exhibition formed a serene, contemplative journey—one that invites viewers to pause, reflect, and momentarily step into a world shaped by light, ritual, and transcendence.







KADER ATTIAS



Kader Attia's work relies on the interdisciplinary exploration of perspectives that societies have on their history, particularly in themes of deprivation and suppression, violence and loss, and how this affects nations and individuals. In 2016, Attia founded La Colonie, which focuses on repairing shattered social and cultural discussions.

Showcased at Lehman Maupin from October 30 to December 20, Attia's works reflect a recognition of the malleable nature and fragility of objects. The main piece, Resonance, features a series of metal bird cages with bells inside, suspended from the ceiling with thick rope. Visitors could interact with the piece by pulling on the rope and engaging in an auditory and tactile experience. To Attia, the cacophonious sounds of layered bells against one another and the swaying of the cages are intended to represent the frequent miscommunication that occurs in society when using social media. The bells also create a metaphor for humanity, each one trying to raise its voice to be heard.



Another one of Attia's pieces is of a green suitcase filled with shattered glass. A light fixture points onto the glass to create a reflection and illuminate the walls. The fractured surface of the glass refracts light in unpredictable directions, producing a shifting pattern that mimics the instability of memory and the fragmentation of personal knowledge. The usage of a suitcase invokes the theme of displacement

and the emotional weight carried by individuals who move across borders. The shattered glass symbolizes the pieces of identity that are often left behind in the process, and when lit, come together to cast lights and shadows, suggesting how many meanings and lessons the human life holds.

Together, the works in Shattering and Gathering our Traces emphasize Attia's belief that rupture and repair coexist. Rather than hiding evidence of damage, Attia highlights it, proposing that scars are essential markers of growth and resilience. The exhibition as a whole encourages viewers to consider how society attempts to mend from historical trauma and how individuals navigate their own narratives.









Headphones ON Beanie

This hand-dyed beanie is made by Gabrielle Trinh, the creative director and designer behind GABBA. Its simple, but eye-catching orange and blue hues are sure to hug your head in a way that makes people turn their heads twice.



Hamburger Wrap

This cheeseburger wrapping paper set may be all you need for your next gifts. This set is brought to you by Milkfarm Artisan Cheese Shop, who specialize in food-centric sundries.

ADM's DESIGN SPOTLIGHT





JUJU Collectible Keychain

Available in 24 varieties, the JUJU collectible key-chain is one of the many creations by CJ Hendry, a New York-based Australian artist who is known for her large-scale, hyper-realistic drawings and immersive installations. JUJU is a floppy-eared little critter that features a recurring flower shape from Hendry's pool pop-ups.

Beads Flat Mug

Scattered with black and mint dots, the pattern on each mug is different due to it being manually made. Whether you decide to use it for a beverage, yogurt, sauce, or fruits, this simple, but bold mug is made to stand out.







Peach Object Diffuser

Phulpy's peach diffuser is made from recycled pulp. Filled with a sweet, sugary peach scent, this set adds a special fragrance from nature to your daily life.





Rotating Brown Wood Stamp

Originating from Japan, this stamp allows you to engage in displaying words, sentences, dates, prices, etc. in a cleaner and fancier way. The brand behind this is 36 Sublo, a small but popular stationery store in the alley of Kichijoji in Tokyo.



Mushroom Lamp

This mushroom lamp from HARRYDAY comes in a green-gray color and sits on a fuzzy green bed. Though currently sold out, HARRYDAY offers an assortment of lamps in different colors and sizes all available on their online store.



everyday



Gallery Mirror

Desiged by the brand
product allows users to
familiar scene of viewers
printed onto a glass mirr



Whipped Cream Pudding

Upon close inspection, this cute plushie is actually a tissue case. Each one is handcrafted by the artists at doingme.mory. The brand offers other variations of this product, such as boxes to resemble mugs of milk and coffee.



Forest Crayon Set

These crayons were created to capture the natural hues of Japan's ten most common trees, with each shade named after the tree it represents. What makes them especially distinctive, however, is that every crayon is infused with fine wood dust from its corresponding tree. The collection was designed by Studio Playfool.

DESIGNS

SAYTOUCHE, this
become the art, as a
s at an art museum is
or.





Fueki-kun Glue

This cute figurine unscrews to reveal an applicator for the perfect craft glue. The yellow dog is Fueki-kun, the mascot for the Japanese stationary brand Fuekie.



Monica Shulman



Artist Profile

Meet this issue's featured artist, Monica Shulman. Monica is a New York–based artist whose work is deeply rooted in the tradition of Abstract Expressionism. Influenced by her background in photography, her travels, and her time working along the Hudson River, her art blends movement, emotion, and place. Working primarily in oil paint and oil pastel, Monica creates both abstract and figurative pieces. Below are highlights from our interview—we hope you enjoy reading!

You've had a very interesting career path. Can you tell us a bit about your life before becoming a full-time artist?

Before becoming a full-time artist, I trained and worked as a corporate lawyer. It was a very different world and career but it taught me discipline, structure, and how to think critically and these are all skills that continue to inform my practice today. Being a lawyer also taught me how to trust myself and my instincts...something that is vital for a career in the arts and for my other full time job as a mother to two kids.

When did you realize you wanted to become an artist? Was there a specific turning point?

Art was always part of my life since I was in high school and later when I was practicing law and shifted from film photography to digital, but the real turning point came when I realized I could no longer ignore the need to create. Leaving law was less about choosing art and more about choosing alignment and sustainability both creatively and personally. It wasn't a dramatic leap, but a gradual realization that I needed to build a life that made creative work possible.

I was working part time as a photographer and exploring other creative pursuits but after I had my second child I went back to work consulting as a lawyer. A few years later my family and I left NYC and moved to the lower Hudson Valley and that's when things started to really shift again. This time in my life was very hectic with two little kids who needed a lot of my mental and physical energy . Around this time I started painting again on a whim and things just evolved organically from there as I started to focus more on that practice after 20 years of not painting.

What was the most challenging part of entering the art world?

The most challenging part was learning to trust my voice and pace in an industry that can sometimes reward visibility over depth. Especially early on, it was hard not to measure myself against timelines that weren't mine. I was also starting from scratch and shaping my practice, portfolio and personal brand without

formal training or guidance. Finding my footing meant resisting comparison and building something intentional rather than reactive.

How has your cultural background shaped your perspective as an artist?

As a Latina and first-generation American, my perspective is shaped by duality... moving between cultures, languages and ways of seeing. That sense of layering and complexity naturally shows up in my work and is a recurring theme in my practice.

How do you handle criticism in the art world, and has your relationship with criticism changed over time?

Earlier in my career, criticism felt very personal. Over time, I've learned to see it as information rather than instruction. As an artist you start to develop a tolerance to criticism and rejection. I try to listen carefully, but I'm much more grounded in trusting my own instincts now, and I've learned that not all feedback deserves equal weight.

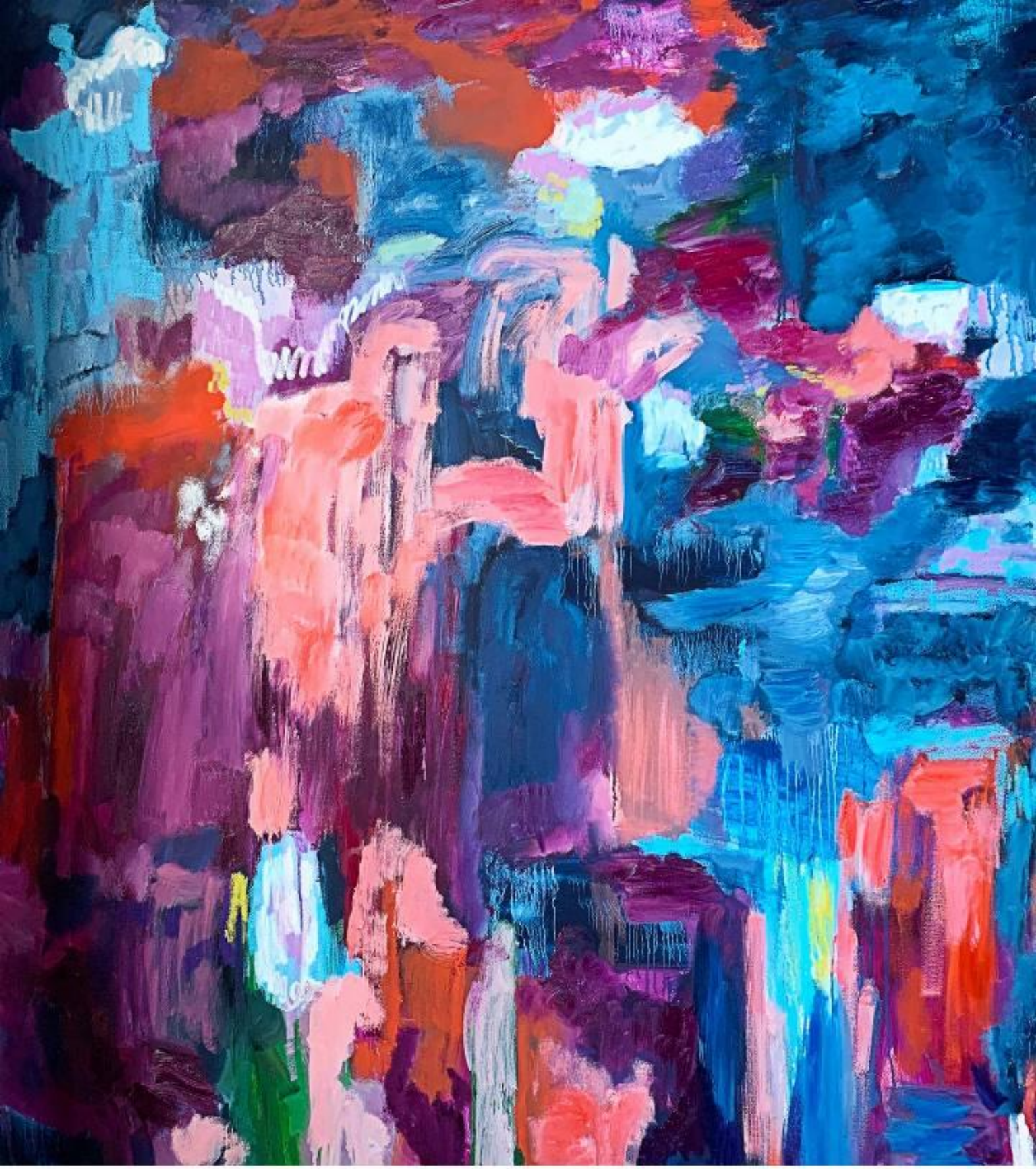
How do you decide when a work is "finished"?

For me, a piece feels finished when it reaches a point of internal balance. It's a very personal decision that is hard to describe because I know it when I feel it. When adding more would resolve the tension rather than deepen it, it feels complete and knowing when to stop is often about restraint.







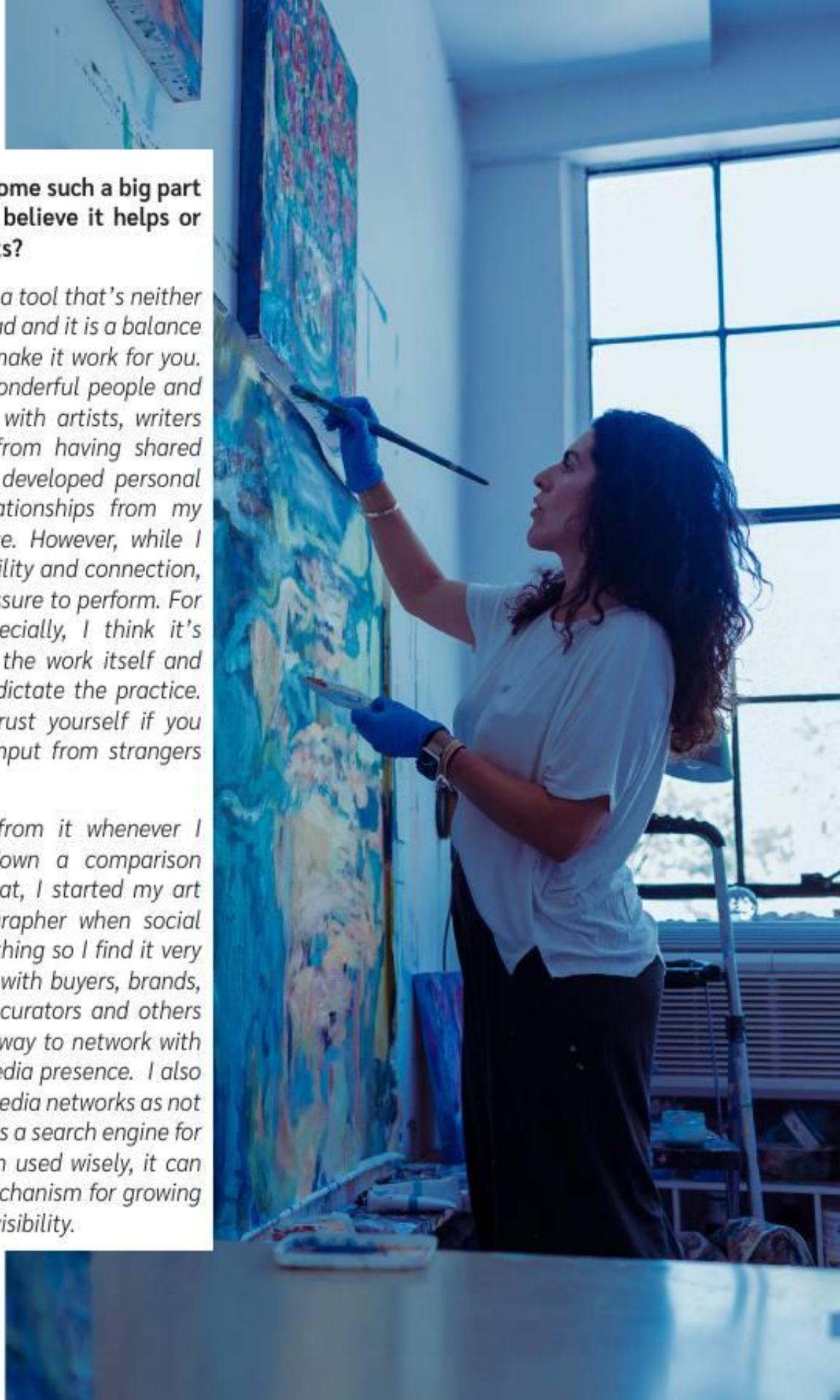


When the Night is Over
Mixed Media Oil Paint and Oil Paint on Canvas
60x72

Social media has become such a big part of our lives. Do you believe it helps or hurts emerging artists?

I think social media is a tool that's neither inherently good nor bad and it is a balance to figure out how to make it work for you. I have met a lot of wonderful people and have become friends with artists, writers and regular people from having shared interests online. I've developed personal and professional relationships from my social media presence. However, while I think it can offer visibility and connection, it can also create pressure to perform. For emerging artists especially, I think it's important to protect the work itself and not let the platform dictate the practice. You can't learn to trust yourself if you consistently rely on input from strangers on the internet.

I try to step away from it whenever I feel myself going down a comparison spiral. Having said that, I started my art practice as a photographer when social media wasn't even a thing so I find it very useful for connecting with buyers, brands, designers, collectors, curators and others who I would have no way to network with if not for my social media presence. I also try to think of social media networks as not only a connector but as a search engine for research...I think when used wisely, it can be a very effective mechanism for growing your practice and for visibility.



What advice would you give to high school students building portfolios or thinking about a career in art?

Focus on curiosity and consistency rather than perfection. Build a body of work that reflects how you think and see, not what you think others want. You're allowed to change your mind, and you don't have to have everything figured out early because careers in art evolve and your work and practice will grow and change.

Network as much and as often as you can. Reach out to people online and go to galleries and art openings. Get comfortable with being outside of your comfort zone, whatever that may be. Talk to fellow artists and develop a collective of people who are in it with you so you can share ideas. An art career can feel very isolating at times so it's important to surround yourself with peers who will understand what it's like and what your goals might be. Trust yourself.

Monica's Work



Meet Me At The River
Oil Canvas
36x38

To see more of Monica's artworks, visit www.monicashulman.com



It's Nearly Light
Oil on Canvas
24x30



I Waded Through
Oil Paint and Oil Pastel on Canvas
30x30



Haunted Mansion 2025

Behind The Scenes

by Hyunseo Joy Ryu

October was a very busy month for the Academy for Visual Arts (AVA) because of our annual Haunted Mansion. This year, this activity was very special. For the first time, the Visual Academy added a carnival with games and food.

Students decided the theme of the haunted carnival even before the school year started in Mr. Lang's Haunted Mansion elective. In the spring of 2025, students were divided into 6 teams: the Ticket Booth, the Fortune-Teller's Room, the Magician's Room, the Clown Room, the Backstage Room, and the Carnival. The AVA students used this elective to decide on the main objects and rough layout for each room, as well as the games for the carnival. Although we didn't start the actual construction, we were able to organize our plans for the Haunted Mansion which made a great base to start.

We began the new school year by confirming the specifics of each room including the materials needed and the "jump scare" for each area. In September, we started building. The Ticket Booth team worked on an old sign with lights that they found in the theatre loft. They were also in charge of making tickets to sell for the Carnival. The Carnival team, led by Hannah, Tiffany, and Melany, handled orders and decorations, making signs, buying prizes, and creating games.

The first room for the Haunted Mansion was the Fortune-Teller's Room.That team spent most of their time preparing the signs that explained what the Fortune-Teller's room was. Then, the final piece that brought the whole room together: the booth that would be used for the jump scare.

The second room was the Magician's Room. Their signature elements were the knife throwing wheel and body sawing trick. While Mr. Torres worked on the effects pieces, the students focused on making decorations such as card towers, posters, and magic equipment.

The third room was the Clown Room. Students designed it to look like a balloon house filled with fake clowns so that real people could jump scare the visitors. While the team bought most of the clothes and wigs online, they spent a great deal of time working on the body shapes and the heads of the clowns.



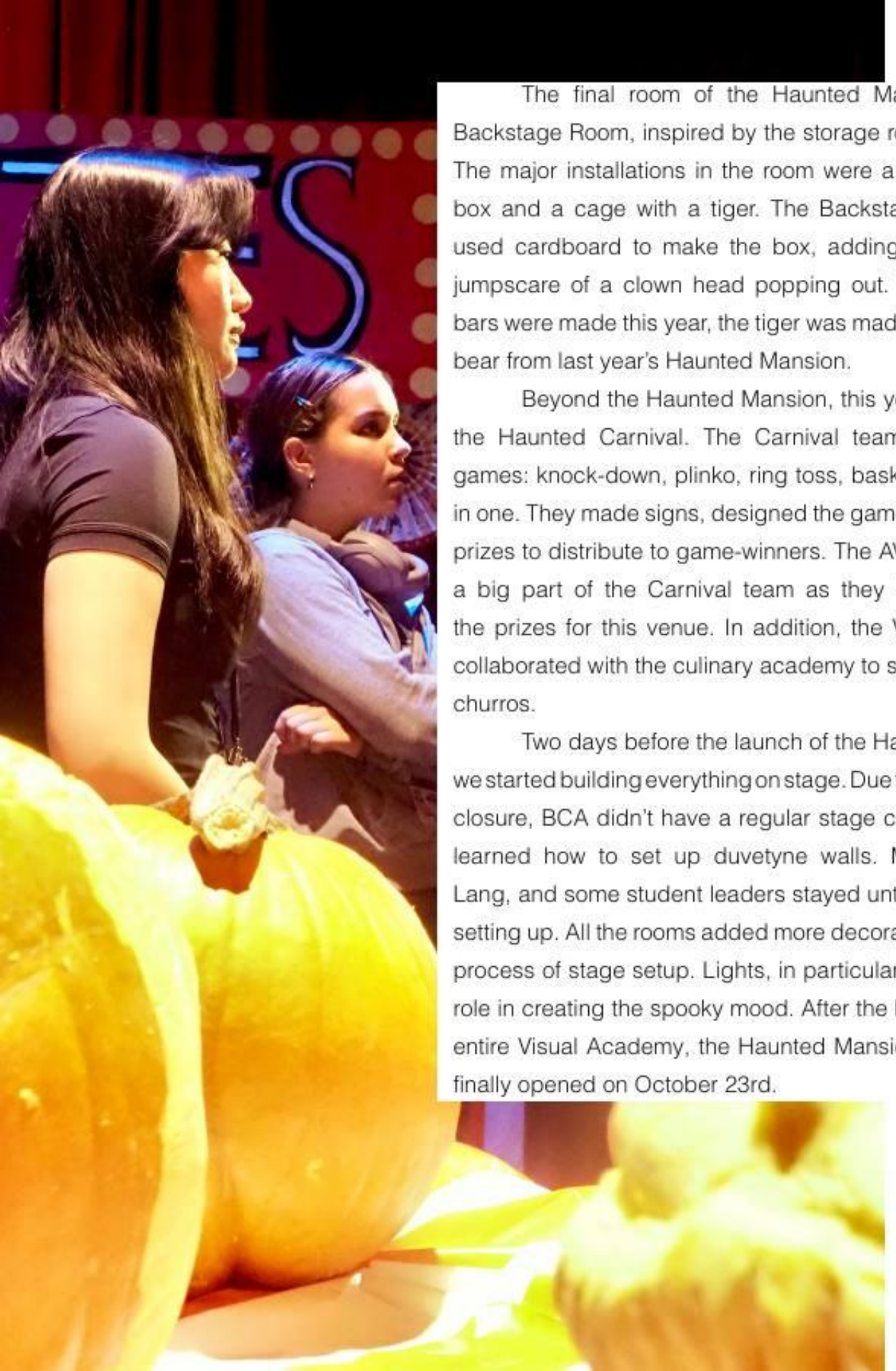
Creating signs for the Carnival games



Adding details to set decorations for the Fortune-Teller's and Magician's Rooms



Painting letters for the main Carnival Sign

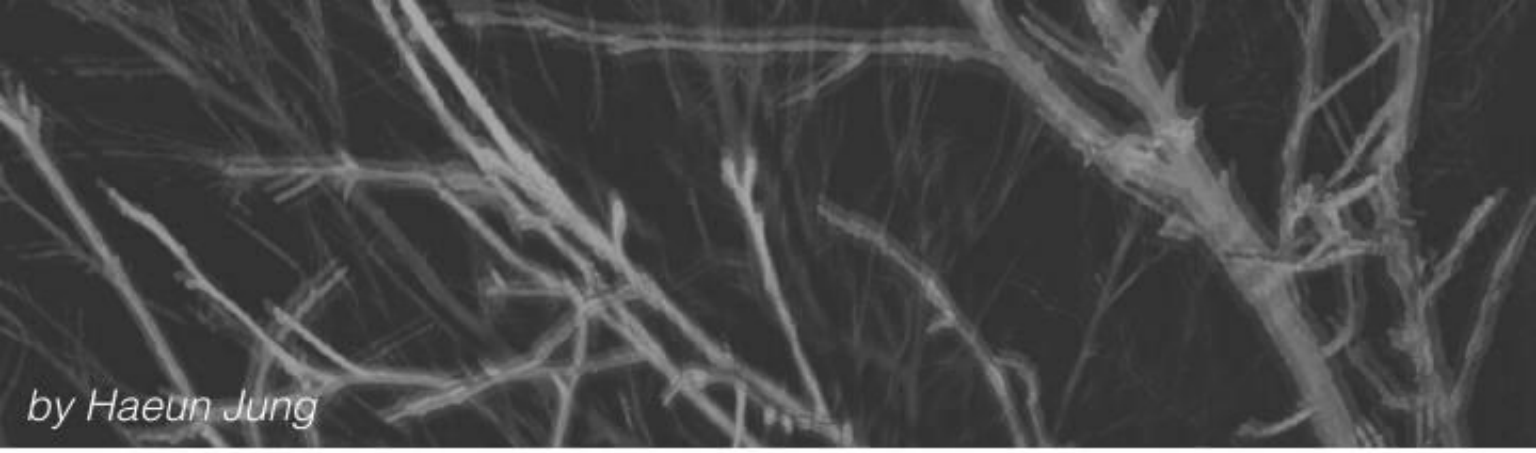


The final room of the Haunted Mansion was the Backstage Room, inspired by the storage room of a circus. The major installations in the room were a huge jack-in-a-box and a cage with a tiger. The Backstage Room team used cardboard to make the box, adding hinges for the jumpscare of a clown head popping out. While the cage bars were made this year, the tiger was made by reusing the bear from last year's Haunted Mansion.

Beyond the Haunted Mansion, this year we also had the Haunted Carnival. The Carnival team prepared five games: knock-down, plinko, ring toss, basketball, and hole in one. They made signs, designed the games, and secured prizes to distribute to game-winners. The AVA parents were a big part of the Carnival team as they bought most of the prizes for this venue. In addition, the Visual Academy collaborated with the culinary academy to sell popcorn and churros.

Two days before the launch of the Haunted Mansion, we started building everything on stage. Due to the auditorium closure, BCA didn't have a regular stage crew so students learned how to set up duvetyne walls. Mr. Guthrie, Mr. Lang, and some student leaders stayed until 11pm to finish setting up. All the rooms added more decorations during the process of stage setup. Lights, in particular, played a huge role in creating the spooky mood. After the hard work of the entire Visual Academy, the Haunted Mansion and Carnival finally opened on October 23rd.

HAUNTED MANSION: haunted carnival



by Haeun Jung

On October 23, Bergen County Academies came alive with a unique blend of thrills and creativity at the school's annual Haunted mansion event designed, created, and run by the Visual academy. This year's theme chosen by this year's leadership group was the Haunted Carnival. With many creepy circus themed elements, guests navigated a series of creatively designed rooms, each filled with eerie decorations, jumpscares, and story. Along with the haunted mansion, guests could also enjoy spending time with friends and family at the carnival complete with games, food, and student-led activities. The event highlighted both the artistic talents of the students and their ability to create an engaging experience for the entire school community, combining event planning, entertainment, and hands-on participation in a way that catered to attendees of all ages.

As guests walked into the event, they were met with a creepy yet fun and busy atmosphere. The smell of churros and popcorn spread throughout the venue, circus music filling the air, and guests eagerly branching through many directions to enjoy the mansion and the carnival added to the interactive and immersive experience. This year introduced a new interactive carnival section which was added onto the usual haunted mansion, bringing a fresh twist to a beloved tradition. Every corner of the stage reflected the event's theme, from the clowns to the carnival games.

One of the main attractions was the Haunted Mansion, a spine-chilling walkthrough designed and run entirely by the visual students. Guests made their way through four, unique themed rooms with specific elements to reflect a fraction of the carnival atmosphere. After guests walk through a long dark hallway introduced with music lingering from the carnival, they would be met with the fortune teller room. Here featured a lone booth in the corner of an overgrown forest, with a glowing crystal ball set on the center table. An unsettling figure would be sitting inside the booth, and as they continued to the next room, the still figure would jolt towards the group. Reactions ranged from laughter to screams as visitors navigated each room.



The Magician room transported guests into the scream-filled magician's quarters. The magician would chainsaw an actor strapped to a mechanism, and guts would spill out of their stomach. Blinding red lights set the bloody atmosphere as missing posters of past victims displayed mysteriously along the entire walls. Each step revealed new surprises from the floating playing cards to the body tied to the wheel of death.



The third room was the clown room, where visitors were forced to face any fears of creepy clowns. The room was covered in balloons, streamers, and lights that hung across the ceiling and walls which added to the eerie, clown-like atmosphere.



The main attraction were the 6 clown manquines. Guests had to navigate and get close to these mannequins to make it through the room, and two clowns were secretly actors who jumpscared attendees as they walked through the room.

The final space was the backstage of the circus, where murderous animals and faulty props were stored, hidden from the public eye. Right by the entrance to the room, a giant jack in the box was stored, popping out at guests as soon as they entered. Behind a large cage lay a vicious tiger, whose head would lunge towards the guests walking past trying to make it to the exit, concluding the experience.



Along with the Haunted Mansion, guests were welcomed into a completely different scene: the Carnival. Contrasting to the creepy atmosphere of the mansion, the carnival provided a burst of color and energy. The carnival featured a variety of attractions: classic carnival games such as knockout, plinko, and basketball, churros and popcorn, as well as face painting and prizes. The food was exclusively made and provided by the culinary students, enhancing the experience for guests. The booths, face painting, and

pumpkin sculptures were all created and run by the visual students, who spent a majority of their time helping during and after school to make sure the event ran smoothly. The blend of artistry and teamwork made the carnival not just an entertaining attraction, but a celebration of the Visual and Culinary student's creativity and community spirit.

The event saw an impressive turnout, with hundreds of students, families, and faculty members filling the venue throughout the evening. From start to finish, the energy remained high as lines formed to enter the mansion and tickets were constantly sold to play more games and win bigger prizes. Crowd favorites included, while Aryn's brother and friends singlehandedly causing an inflation in prize prices became one of the night's most talked-about moments

Teachers and administrators praised the effort behind the event, emphasizing the creativity and collaboration of the Visual students. Mr. Russell Davis, principle of the Bergen County Academies, shared, "The teachers and students truly outdid themselves this year, especially wuth the addition of the carnival theme and the evening session that allowed families of our students and staff to take part." Meanwhile, English teacher Ms. Xu said, "It was an awesome event to close off the Halloween season! From beginning to end, the students, faculty, and staff put so much time and hard work into organizing the sets and interactive experiences to create a fantastic Haunted Mansion experience." Students reflected on the experience with pride as well as relief, sharing how the months (or weeks) of preparation paid off. For younger guests, the event offered a blend of excitement and engagement. By the end of the night, the event had proven to be more than just a seasonal celebration. It was a showcase of the Visual student's creativity, collaboration, and community spirit that left everyone eagerly awaiting next year's event.

As the night came to a close, the event stood as a testament to the dedication and teamwork of the team. Weeks of planning, designing, and creating came together to create an experience that left guests both thrilled and inspired. Students and staff alike reflected proudly on how their efforts paid off, transforming the space into something truly memorable. A visual student commented, "The effort we poured in over such a short amount of time made it even more meaningful. When I saw all the families and students enjoying themselves, laughing, bonding, and smiling, I truly felt that all the hard work had paid off." Looking ahead, organizers hint at continuing on expanding their plans for the future. The academy extends their gratitude to everyone who attended, supported, or helped bring the event to life and helped support the academy for bigger and better projects for the future. They look forward to showing more of what they can do.



